

HARVESTING GOODWILL

By facilitating the construction of a warehouse in tsunami-hit Vizhunthamavadi, CARE TODAY makes it easier for farmers to store and sell their foodgrain

CARE TODAY
AN INDIA TODAY GROUP INITIATIVE

For farmers in Vizhunthamavadi village along the Nagappattinam coast of Tamil Nadu, the deadly tsunami wreaked havoc—it claimed 23 lives and destroyed 248 hectares of the total 939 hectares of cultivable land. Tidal waves damaged cash crops like paddy, ground nut and cashew nut, and inundated arable land, leaving behind heavy salt deposits and rendering it infertile. Even the warehouses where the farmers stored foodgrain were destroyed.

Moved by the plight of these hapless farmers, CARE TODAY with the help of a local partner, Dhan Foundation, a Madurai-based NGO, constructed a warehouse in the village. The villagers of Vizhunthamavadi and neighbouring Pudhupalli extended their help in the construction of the 250 sq m warehouse which was built at a cost of Rs 13.27 lakh.

The warehouse seemed the perfect answer to the problems of the farmers who needed a place to store their grain. In the absence of a storage place, they had to depend on middlemen to sell their foodgrain. Taking advantage of the situation, middlemen reaped rich profits—they bought foodgrain from the farmers at abysmally low prices and sold them at

high rates in the market.

Dedicating the warehouse to the people of Vizhunthamavadi, CARE TODAY Secretary Prabhu Chawla said, "Farmers are the *annadatas*

(providers of food) of the nation and in their growth lies the prosperity of the country. We at CARE TODAY are ready to help them." Touched by this kind gesture, a villager said, "The warehouse will help us store our foodgrain safely when the prices are low and sell when they are high. CARE TODAY's timely intervention has helped us a lot." T. Ambigapathi, a local farmer, was relieved because the warehouse meant less dependence on middlemen. "We thank CARE TODAY for their valuable contribution. The middlemen's game is over."

CARE TODAY, which acts as a link between INDIA TODAY Group's readers, viewers and listeners on the one side and disaster-hit communities on the other, received Rs 2.79 crore in contribution to make life better for people in tsunami-hit areas in India. Of this, it has so far released grants of Rs 2.23 crore. The organisation has provided

relief and rehabilitation to people in tsunami-hit Nagappattinam, Tuticorin and Tirunelveli districts in Tamil Nadu, Kachal in Little Andaman and the southern parts of the Nicobar islands.



Photographs by ANAND NATRAJAN

STORE AND STAND: (above) CARE TODAY Secretary Prabhu Chawla at the inauguration; newly-constructed warehouse

